

3 Days In New York

I'm Going Where Now?

Friday afternoon I'm working from home trying to get some actual work done during a conference call when all of a sudden I head the words "...and we'll send Matt out to New York next week." Myself being the only Matt on the project and having been told nothing of travel anywhere much less New York I'm understandably confused.

It turned out that yes, they did want me out on the east coast for 2 days and that I would be flying out the following Monday. Unfortunately travel approval had not been given by the client so my PM tells me not to book anything just yet.

Saturday passes with no word and I start to assume I won't be going to New York. Sunday morning brings a surprise, the client gave approval for travel the following day.

What followed was a rush of panicked travel arrangements. I was actually laughed at by the reservation desk of one of the local hotels when I asked for a reservation for the next day. Marriott customer service gives me the choice of a room in New Jersey or out by the airport. From what I've been told of New Jersey I pick the airport.

7 am the next morning after maneuvering through some unknown backup-causing crisis at the local airport I was off. I hadn't heard back from my PM since Friday so at this point I wasn't sure I was even supposed to be traveling that day. I sent emails and made a series of calls to the effect "I'm about to board an airplane to head out to New York, please call me back rather quickly if I'm not supposed to" but all I get is voicemail.

I try the same thing in Denver, reaching my home office but no one can seem to reach our PM. I board the plane to New York. While boarding I chatter with someone who turned out to live in New York. When I told him this was my first time in New York and I was staying near the airport he got rather panicked looking and proceeded to call his office to help me find another hotel. Turns out its too late to rebook at this point so I will spend my first night in Flushing New York.

A relaxing 3+ hour flight ensued with not one but two screaming infants (one in front and one in back for a nice stereo effect) and a pair of women in the row behind me talking loudly over the babies for the entire flight about the various remodeling tasks they were performing in their children's rooms. I bring earplugs with me on every flight but they hardly make a dent.

Refreshed and still not sure I was even supposed to be there I land at LaGuardia at 6:30 pm.



This is LaGuardia. The shopping area isn't bad but the terminals themselves are cramped and appear to always be full due to the amount of delayed flights on the runway at any given time.



I'm staying in a Marriott over in Flushing which I'm told is a part of Queens. Basically the airport shuttle left Lagaardia and took every turn towards a worse area and then made it to the hotel. Upon arriving he pulls up right next to the door, grabs my bag, and rushes me inside so fast you'd think raging hordes of cannibals were lurking outside. I take one look around, decide maybe he's not to far off, and run after him.

For \$200 a night the hotel is rather basic. My question about sit down restaurants within walking distance is met with looks of horror so I settle for delivery. I send an email to my PM and determine at long last that yes, I should be in New York right now. Hurray!

Everyone I speak to for the rest of the trip when I relate I spent the previous night in Flushing has the same reaction: My god, why?

Matt's First Day In New York

I check out of the hotel having been told we'll get me in a nicer room the following day closer to Pfizer.

On my PMs instructions I take a cab into the city but it turns out I picked the wrong color (yellow vs black, go figure.) I make it to Pfizer tired but relatively unscathed.



This is the fancy world headquarters of Pfizer. I am immediately disappointed when not only do they not have free samples of Viagra available in the lobby but we're actually working down the street in a rather less fancy Pfizer building.

I meet my PM Rob for the first time, all 6 foot 6 inches of him. He makes a good addition to the project tech lead who is also a cage fighter.



He takes me into the main Pfizer lobby in order to get my bags scanned and my picture taken for a visitors badge.

When I'm cleared we head up our somewhat less fancy building into a maze of faded white walls to a small room that we're allowed use of though it hasn't been officially given to us. Home sweet home.

How To Attend A Meeting In Pfizer

We are up on the 11th floor behind several doors that only open with a key card which we do not have. Our visitor badges are only enough to get us in the front door IF someone is with us that has a real badge.

Two Pfizer people are with us as we set off to a conference room in another building for our meeting.

Now Pfizer has multiple buildings that seem to span more than one block. There are connections between buildings in the same block on various levels though there seems to be no rhyme or reason behind where. Getting from floor to floor is also an adventure because a given elevator bank only goes to some of the floors. Even people who have been there for years still show some confusion about navigation because our two Pfizer people argue about the route for most of the trip.

I silent wonder what happens to interns who come to Pfizer for the summer. As we pass endless offices I start to think that somewhere in there is the skeletal remains of an intern still clutching the disc they were told to run over to someone in another building.

At some point we end up at ground level crossing the street. When we try and enter it turns out our badges are not valid for this building even though we have Pfizer visitor badges and actual Pfizer people with us. Instead we have to go back outside and around to the lobby of this building to have our bags rescanned and get another badge.

Here is there a problem however as they went to take our old visitor badges away and give us ones only valid for this building which means we won't be able to get back to our temporary office space. At long last with arguing we are granted the honor of temporary badges with the all powerful designation of ALL which will allow us into any Pfizer building as long as we don't try and use an employee entrance and we have a person with a real badge in tow.

More intra-building navigation follows and we finally make it to our conference room. Exhausted from our trek we settle in for a three hour meeting where I'm pretty sure we make negative progress. And this was the main reason for brining me out. A follow-up meeting is scheduled for the day after I get home at 9 am (6 am Pacific.)

My Night Out

We make it back from our meeting only to find the rest of the Crown team inexplicably absent. Phone calls are made and it turns out everyone is either out with their girlfriend, on an airplane, committed to family things, already asleep, or Matt.

Fortunately we found a better hotel so I'm set if I can just get there.

Rob feels bad for not being able to take me out and tries to get me to go to some big name place for dinner promising he'll let me expense dinner. When he calls and asks for a reservation for one we hear a sound that we're pretty sure is someone laughing at us while covering the phone. It turns out I'm underdressed anyway so scrap that.

We grab a taxi since Rob's train station is on the way.

Traffic is...well...New York like with cars darting every which way. At one point our taxi is cut off and our driver performs a series of maneuvers to catch up with the offending cab. After they both roll their windows down our driver proceeds to tell the other that he cut him off, he is a horrible person, and that when he doesn't have his cab anymore he will have nothing. I wave at the passengers of the other cab and wait to see if anyone will be shot.

We drive through Time Square which I'm rather impressed by but Rob assures me I don't want to wander through. Something about the highest amount of pickpocketings of any

area of New York. He does try to get the taxi to pull over long enough for me to get a picture which turns out to be a rather bad idea in rush hour Manhattan. After a near altercation I decide a picture out the back window is just fine:



I check in to my hotel just on the other side of the Brooklyn bridge. The room is nice though I think it was on the furthest possible point away from the elevator. I could have hit the bed and been out at that point but Rob was feeling so bad about me being abandoned my one night in New York proper I figure I owe it to him to go out.

On his advice I get a taxi over to Seaport which I proceed to try and call South Port and Seashore to blank looks by the valet and taxi driver. After a short geography lesson we go across the bridge and I'm on my own in Manhattan.

I wander around a bit trying to find a restaurant that looks decent and snapping a few pictures. View of the city from Seaport:



I settle on a brewery that turns out to be quite good. Two beers and a steak later I set off to find Ground Zero which I have been told by Rob is in walking distance. Unfortunately directions are not Rob's strong suit so I head off down several streets as he calls my cell from time to time asking me to describe where I am. My descriptions of people hawking illegal movies, worrying gouts of steam coming from holes in the sidewalk, and some nice fellows trying to sell me a variety of items out of their trunk don't seem to help.

Sometime later, success!



I wander around and take a picture through the fence but there isn't a whole lot to see. Construction was going on (loudly) at 10 at night.



It's after 10 and I have another full day ahead of me tomorrow so I start looking for a taxi. After walking by the fellows selling items out of their trunk and the illegal movie man again I'm on my way back to the hotel.

Exhausted after a long day I was out as soon as I hit the pillow.

They Have Tornadoes In Brooklyn?

I woke up the next morning to a strange booming coming through the building. This was a rather large well insulated hotel building so it was quite a racket. After being woken up several times I got up to look out the window.

What had sounded like a jet buzzing the hotel was actually thunder reverberating off the other buildings. Lighting was going off at a rather astonishing rate though I couldn't see the forks from where I was and rain was coming down in sheets.



I watched for a bit before things calmed down. I ate breakfast downstairs and overheard a few people mentioning they didn't want to go into Manhattan with things being so gross outside but I assumed it was just the rain they were talking about.

When I stepped out of the hotel to hail a taxi I was greeted by a line of rather anxious looking business people. I also noticed there was a rather large amount of car and pedestrian traffic heading for the Brooklyn Bridge.

It turns out the storm that woke me up had spawned the first tornado in the area in recorded history about 5 miles south of me. The amount of rain had flooding out the subway, downed trees, started minor fires, and knocked power out to a few surrounding areas. My knack for running into interesting situations seems to be intact.

The hotel valet had to practically throw himself on taxis to get them to pull into the hotel driveway but a short time later I was sharing a cab with two others and making my way slowly into Manhattan. One of the other passengers was a producer with NBC and shared with me what all was happening and that, no, it was not normal to see people in suits and heels walking across the Brooklyn Bridge. I settle back and watch the show as we pass flooded streets and see emergency vehicles going every which way.

In Manhattan things were even more chaotic. Buses weren't all running and taxis were so scarce my PM actually saw three people arguing over who would get into a stopped

taxi only to have another woman run across the street and jump in the other side before being bodily hauled out by the original trio.

A day of phone calls and negative progress proceeds. I remark to myself this is the most expensive negative work I've ever done considering travel costs.

Escape From New York

Finally I was done at Pfizer and off to the airport. Once I got there it turned out my flight was delayed an hour. Then every flight was delayed and some for unspecified amounts of time. Then the power went out to the check in area meaning no one could get their boarding passes. I was already through at this point so I did the only sensible thing I could think of and had a beer.

My flight boards after only an hours delay and the captain cheerfully tells us we're going to have about a 40 minute taxi time but it's ok! Their going to show us both Spiderman 3 and Shrek The Third. At this point my layover time in Denver is almost used up.

We try to back out from the gate and just in time someone on the ground realizes there's another plane behind us and slams on the brake. The captain comes over the intercom and apologizes for the near fender bender. I'm watching Spiderman.



We get into the air and with a minimal amount of bumps land in Denver. My connecting flight has changed gates 3 times since I left New York and is due to take off any time now. Determining that the final gate is conveniently the one furthest away from me I proceed to run at a breakneck pace across the terminal nearly giving several people a heart attack as I hurl by them on the moving sidewalks with my fully loaded laptop backpack swinging back and forth as I go.

I make the gate just in time and I'm hustled inside by a flight attendant. The flight is only about half full because a number of people supposed to be on the flight either had their connecting flights canceled or are still trying to get to Denver. Our flight can't be delayed because we not have exactly 27 minutes of fudge time before we'll be denied access to the Orange County airport when it closes down for the night. A few weeks ago when I was on a similar flight we left 40 people behind.

Fortunately for me this means the middle seat is open. For most of the 2 hour flight I chat with a retired professional Canadian weightlifter in the aisle seat and look out the window as the plane is thrown all over the place by turbulence. I remark to myself that

I've become rather less nervous about flying after a few months at Crown as I try to keep my decaf from flying across the cabin.

The plane lands a bit ahead of scheduled and I limp off the plane. It turns out running across a terminal with a weight on your back isn't the best of things for a hiking injury.

I get home around midnight and just about pass out. The kind folks at Pfizer had scheduled a conference call for 6 am pacific the next morning though so I don't get to oversleep.

I found out a few days later I will be sent back to New York for another 2 day visit next week. As of now it's Saturday and travel approval has not been given...